

Print Content

How to Use This Checklist

- Tick the box (– []) each time you try a dish.
- Add a quick note or a 1-5 star rating in the margin.
- Don't aim to finish everything — use it to discover, not to rush.
- Some dishes may not be available in every city or season.

1. Noodles & Rice Bowls

Dish	One-line note	Tried
Ramen (shoyu)	Soy-based broth, the classic starting point	– []
Ramen (tonkotsu)	Rich, creamy pork-bone broth	– []
Ramen (miso)	Hearty fermented-soybean broth	– []
Tsukemen	Dipping noodles, broth served separately	– []
Udon	Thick, chewy wheat noodles, hot or cold	– []
Soba	Buckwheat noodles, often served cold with dip	– []
Yakisoba	Stir-fried noodles, popular street food	– []
Gyudon	Simmered beef over rice	– []
Katsudon	Breaded pork cutlet with egg over rice	– []
Oyakodon	Chicken and egg over rice	– []
Tendon	Tempura over rice with sweet sauce	– []
Unadon	Grilled eel over rice	– []
Curry rice	Mild Japanese-style curry over rice	– []
Omurice	Omelette over ketchup-flavored fried rice	– []
Chazuke	Rice with tea or broth poured over	– []

2. Sushi & Raw Fish

Dish	One-line note	Tried
Nigiri sushi	Fish over hand-pressed rice	– []
Maki sushi	Rolled sushi wrapped in seaweed	– []
Temaki	Hand-rolled cone of seaweed and rice	– []

Chirashi	Assorted toppings over a bowl of rice	- []
Sashimi	Sliced raw fish, no rice	- []
Conveyor-belt sushi	Affordable plates on a moving belt	- []
Salmon nigiri	A reliable favorite for first-timers	- []
Tuna (maguro)	Lean to fatty cuts, ask for the cut you like	- []
Sea urchin (uni)	Creamy, briny, an acquired taste	- []
Salmon roe (ikura)	Bursting orange roe	- []

3. Grilled, Fried & Hot Pot

Dish	One-line note	Tried
Tempura	Lightly battered, deep-fried seafood and veg	- []
Tonkatsu	Breaded, deep-fried pork cutlet	- []
Karaage	Japanese-style fried chicken	- []
Yakitori	Skewered, grilled chicken	- []
Yakiniku	Grill-it-yourself meat at your table	- []
Sukiyaki	Sweet-savory hot pot, dip in raw egg	- []
Shabu-shabu	Swish thin meat in hot broth	- []
Teppanyaki	Iron-griddle cooking, often tableside	- []
Gyoza	Pan-fried dumplings	- []
Tofu hot pot	Light, warming pot of tofu and veg	- []
Motsunabe	Offal hot pot, rich and warming	- []

4. Street Food & Snacks

Dish	One-line note	Tried
Takoyaki	Octopus-filled batter balls	- []
Okonomiyaki	Savory cabbage pancake, build-your-own toppings	- []
Taiyaki	Fish-shaped cake, sweet filling	- []
Onigiri	Rice ball, dozens of fillings	- []
Korokke	Crispy potato croquette	- []
Imagawayaki	Round cake filled with sweet bean paste	- []
Dango	Chewy rice dumplings on a skewer	- []

Yaki-imo	Roasted sweet potato, a winter favorite	- []
Senbei	Savory rice crackers	- []
Croquette sandwich	Fried croquette in soft bread	- []

5. Sweets & Desserts

Dish	One-line note	Tried
Mochi	Chewy pounded rice cake	- []
Daifuku	Mochi filled with sweet bean paste	- []
Dorayaki	Pancakes sandwiching sweet bean paste	- []
Matcha soft serve	Green tea ice cream	- []
Anmitsu	Jelly cubes, fruit, and sweet syrup	- []
Castella	Light honey sponge cake	- []
Parfait	Tall layered dessert, very popular	- []
Kakigori	Shaved ice with syrup (summer)	- []
Wagashi	Traditional seasonal sweets	- []
Melon pan	Sweet crusted bread bun	- []

6. Drinks

Drink	One-line note	Tried
Green tea	Everyday tea, served hot or cold	- []
Matcha	Whisked powdered green tea	- []
Sake	Rice wine, served warm or chilled	- []
Shochu	Distilled spirit, many base ingredients	- []
Highball	Whisky and soda, very common	- []
Craft beer	Growing local brewery scene	- []
Ramune	Marble-stopper soda, fun to open	- []
Calpis	Sweet, milky soft drink	- []
Vending machine coffee	Hot or cold, available everywhere	- []

(Note: alcoholic drinks for of-age travelers only.)

7. Regional Specialties

Look for these where you happen to be — many are tied to a specific area.

Dish	Region / one-line note	Tried
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White shrimp (shiroebi)	Toyama — delicate, sweet local shrimp, often as sashimi or tempura	- []
Firefly squid (hotaru-ika)	Toyama — small squid, a spring specialty	- []
Buri (yellowtail)	Toyama coast — prized winter fish	- []
Masu-zushi	Toyama — pressed trout sushi wrapped in bamboo leaf	- []
Himi udon	Himi area — hand-pulled, thin and springy udon	- []
Kombujime	Toyama — fish cured between kelp sheets	- []
Hokkaido seafood bowl	North — generous bowls of fresh seafood	- []
Hokkaido dairy soft serve	North — rich milk-based ice cream	- []
Hiroshima-style okonomiyaki	West — layered with noodles	- []
Osaka takoyaki & kushikatsu	Kansai — street-food capital staples	- []
Kyoto-style tofu & kaiseki	Kansai — refined seasonal cuisine	- []
Nagoya miso katsu	Central — cutlet with rich miso sauce	- []
Fukuoka tonkotsu ramen	South — birthplace of the creamy pork broth	- []
Okinawa goya champuru	South — bitter-melon stir-fry	- []
Sendai gyutan	North — grilled beef tongue	- []

(Availability and seasons vary — confirm locally.)

8. My Own Discoveries

Add dishes you found along the way.

Dish	Where / note	Tried
		- []
		- []
		- []
		- []
		- []
		- []
		- []
		- []

Notes

Use this space for favorites, allergy reminders, and dishes to try next time.
